Coverage, Backup, Handoff

The words behind a care arrangement and what to write down for each.

Once a move is being planned, people start saying coverage, backup and handoff as if everyone had agreed what they mean. This sheet gives each word one plain line and something to write down beside it.

The first group are the Family Care Roadmap's own planning words. The second and third are defined from public sources. None of them is for judging the plan yourself. They're for describing it clearly to the people who will.

The planning words

Coverage

A named person who has confirmed they'll be there, with a day and a time. An offer without a day and a time isn't coverage yet.

WRITE DOWN Who, which days, which hours.

Coverage gap

A stretch of the day or night with no name beside it. It's a fact about the plan, not a finding about his safety.

WRITE DOWN The day and the times, and who you've told.

Overnight

The hours between bedtime and breakfast, written as their own block instead of being assumed.

WRITE DOWN Who is in the house, and who gets up if he does.

Handoff

The point where one helper leaves and the next arrives, or where his care passes from one team to another.

WRITE DOWN The time, who is leaving, who is arriving, and what they tell each other.

Backup

The named person or service that steps in when the planned helper can't come. AARP's planning guide makes a similar point about teams: a wide one helps make sure you still have support as people's ability to help changes. [1]

WRITE DOWN A name and a phone number for each part of the week, or “none yet.”

Supervision

Used here in the everyday sense: someone being with him, close by, or reachable while he does things himself. How much he needs is for the people who assess him to say.

WRITE DOWN For each part of the day, whether someone is planned to be present, nearby or reachable by phone.

Observed concern

Something you saw or were told, written as what happened and not what it means.

WRITE DOWN What, where and when, and who saw it.

Unresolved question

A safety or care question nobody has answered yet. Once you've passed it to a professional it has been referred. It isn't cleared until they answer.

WRITE DOWN The question, who has it, and the date you asked.

Owner

The person who has agreed to follow up on a concern or a gap.

WRITE DOWN One name on each line, and what they said they'd do.

People and kinds of help

Caregiver

Anyone who helps care for an older person or a person with a disability who lives at home, usually with activities of daily living and essentials like shopping, preparing meals and housework. [2]

WRITE DOWN Everyone this describes, starting with you.

Activities of daily living (ADLs)

The basic actions of a day: bathing, dressing, transferring (moving to and from a bed or a chair), eating, and caring for incontinence. [2]

WRITE DOWN Which ones someone will be helping with, and at what time of day.

Personal care (custodial care)

Non-skilled help, such as a hand with bathing, dressing, eating, getting in and out of bed or a chair, moving around and using the bathroom. [2]

WRITE DOWN Who is giving it at each part of the day.

Respite care

Temporary care intended to give time off to those who care for someone on a regular basis. It can be provided at home, in an adult day service center or in a nursing home. [2]

WRITE DOWN Whether anyone on the care team has mentioned it, and who you'd ask.

Paper and contacts

Discharge planning

A process that determines the kind of care a patient needs after leaving the hospital. A number of people can carry it out; only a physician can authorize the release. [3]

WRITE DOWN Who is handling it for your husband, and their direct number.

Existing professional instructions

What the professionals have already told you to do, starting with the written discharge instructions. Medicare's checklist says to ask for them in a form you can read and understand. [4]

WRITE DOWN Where your copy is, its date and who gave it to you.

Drug list

The full list of the prescription drugs, over-the-counter drugs, vitamins and herbal supplements he takes, to review with the staff. [4]

WRITE DOWN Who holds the list today, and who will after the move.

Professional contact

The person on the care team a question goes to. Medicare's checklist says to write down the names and phone numbers of people to call with questions or concerns. [4]

WRITE DOWN Name, role and phone number, beside each open question.

Care plan

A form where a person's health conditions, specific care needs and current treatments are summarized in one place. [5]

WRITE DOWN Whether he has one, who wrote it, and its date.

What this sheet doesn't do

It defines words. It doesn't say how much supervision your husband needs, which kind of help fits, or whether the plan has enough of anything. That's for the people who assess him.

Ready for the next step?

You have the words, and something written beside each one. The care interview asks about the same things in plain questions: your husband's needs, his safety and who is helping, one area at a time. It turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. Administration for Community Living, Glossary
3. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
4. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Your Discharge Planning Checklist (CMS Product No. 11376)
5. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan